Review Analysis for Banff Caribou Lodge & Spa

Competitive Landscape — Banff, Alberta

Introduction

Online guest reviews represent an unsolicited, unfiltered view of the customer experience and are a primary input in hotel selection decisions. Research indicates that 86% of consumers are reluctant to purchase from businesses with a high volume of negative reviews, making review sentiment a material driver of occupancy and revenue. This report analyzes Google Maps and TripAdvisor reviews for Banff Caribou Lodge & Spa and three direct competitors, identifying key strengths, service gaps, and actionable opportunities for Banff Lodging Co.

This analysis identifies three priority actions for Banff Lodging Co. with respect to Banff Caribou Lodge & Spa. First, update pool and amenity descriptions across the hotel website and OTA listings to accurately reflect the facilities available. Second, implement a structured review response program. With an owner response rate of just 0.2% compared to 20% for competitors, there is an opportunity to publicly show that Banff Caribou acknowledges guest feedback. Third, increase the frequency of front desk service monitoring; sentiment analysis identifies the front desk as a persistent weak point spanning multiple years, and targeted staff training and accountability measures are warranted.

Methodology

Reviews were scraped from Google Maps and TripAdvisor for five Banff properties covering all available historical data through March 2026. For each review, I collected the date, overall star rating (1–5), component ratings for Rooms, Service, and Location where available, full review text, stay context (travel group, trip type), and owner response data. Review volumes by property are shown in the following table.

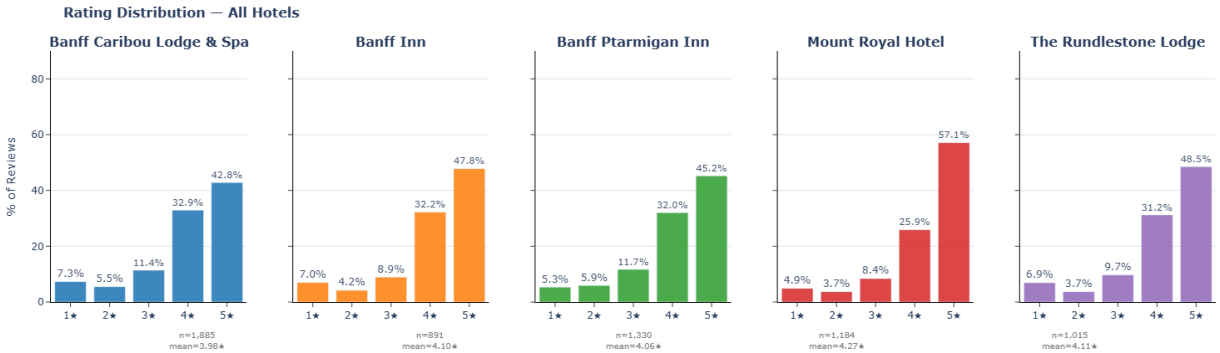
Property	Number of Reviews
Banff Caribou Lodge & Spa	1887
Banff Ptarmigan Inn	1331
Mount Royal Hotel	1186
The Rundlestone Lodge	1016
Banff Inn	891

Using sentiment analysis (VADER) and natural language processing (spaCy), Iextracted aspects mentioned across all reviews. I identified how frequently each aspect appears and whether the surrounding context is positive, negative, or neutral. Aspects were then grouped into six business-relevant categories: Service, Rooms, Amenities, Location, Value, and Food & Breakfast. This allows for systematic comparison of guest sentiment across properties and over time.

Findings

Banff Caribou Lodge & Spa Trails the Competitive Set on Ratings

Across all five properties, Banff Caribou Lodge & Spa records the lowest mean star rating (3.98) and the lowest proportion of 5★ reviews (42.8%), as shown in Figure 1 and Table 2 below. Mount Royal Hotel leads the competitive set with a mean rating of 4.27 and 57.1% five-star reviews.



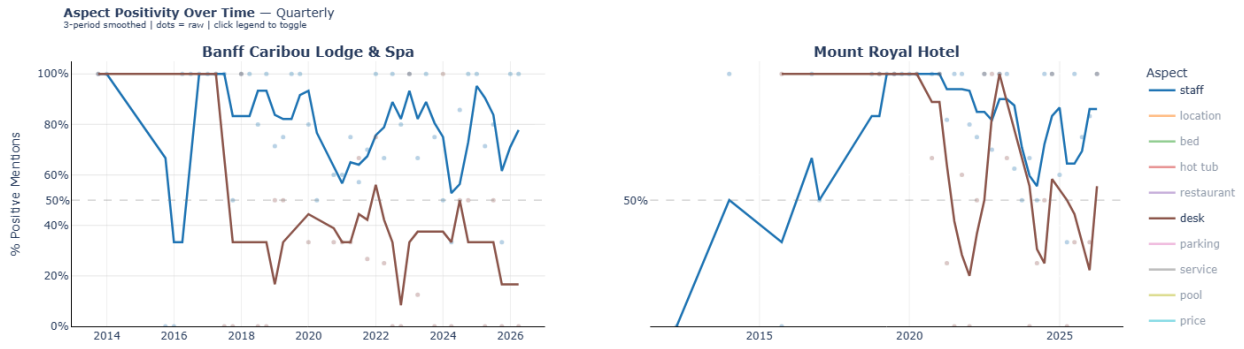
Lower owner response rate

Banff Caribou Lodge & Spa has an owner response rate of just 0.2%,publicly responding to fewer than 1 in 500 reviews. This compares unfavourably with Mount Royal Hotel (25.0%) and The Rundlestone Lodge (29.6%). Unanswered 1★ reviews are visible to prospective guests and signal that complaints go unacknowledged.

Hotel	Average rating	Percent 5★	Percent 1★	Owner Response
Banff Caribou Lodge & Spa	3.98	42.77	7.37	0.16
Banff Inn	4.10	47.81	6.96	5.27
Banff Ptarmigan Inn	4.06	45.23	5.33	0.00
Mount Royal Hotel	4.27	57.08	4.89	24.96
The Rundlestone Lodge	4.11	48.43	6.89	29.63

Front Desk Experience Is a Persistent Weak Point at Banff Caribou

Sentiment analysis of review text identifies "desk" (front desk) as one of the most frequently mentioned aspects across all properties and one of the clearest differentiators between Banff Caribou Lodge & Spa and the competitive set. As shown in Figure 2, front desk sentiment at Banff Caribou has remained predominantly below the 50% positivity threshold throughout the review period, with a notable deterioration in recent quarters.

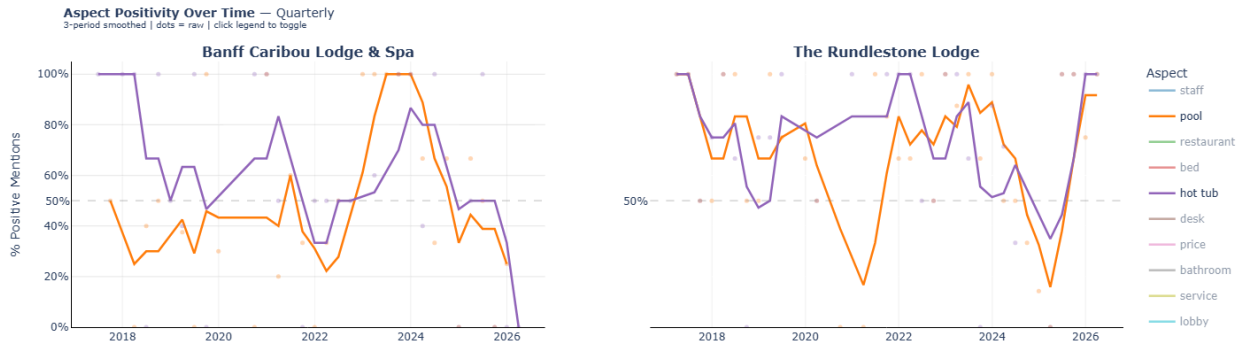


This pattern is corroborated by recent guest reviews. A guest from the past year wrote that upon arrival they were met by a front desk clerk who was dismissive and interrupting, noting it was "not a nice way to start the day." A second guest independently described front desk staff as "not friendly and welcoming."

The front desk leaves the first and last impression of every stay. Staff training, service standard reinforcement, and more frequent guest satisfaction monitoring at the front desk level are warranted.

Amenity Misrepresentation Is Driving Preventable Negative Reviews

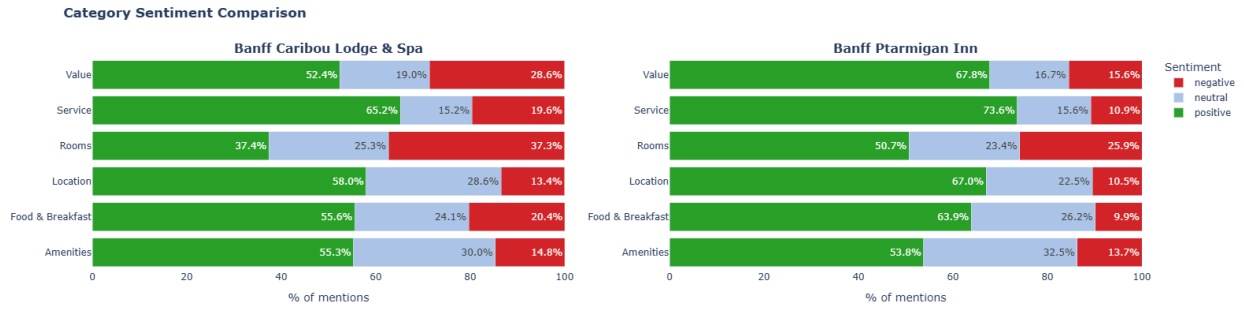
Banff Caribou Lodge & Spa markets a 26 jetted hot tub pool as a headline amenity, and it is frequently a mentioned aspect in guest reviews. Pool and hot tub sentiment at Banff Caribou has trended downward significantly since 2024, with hot tub positivity falling to near zero in the most recent quarter.



The driver is a mismatch between guest expectations set by marketing materials and the reality of the amenity. Recent reviews make this explicit. One guest noted that the property's "pool" is in fact a large hot tub, adding "don't bring your kids here", which indicates that families are arriving expecting a lap or leisure pool and finding something materially different.

Guests who feel misled are more likely to leave negative reviews regardless of other aspects of their stay, and the effect is compounded when those guests have specifically chosen the property on the basis of the amenity. Two targeted actions would address this directly: updating website and OTA listing copy to accurately describe the hot tub facilities and set appropriate expectations for families, and proactively communicating amenity details at the time of booking confirmation. The cost of these changes is negligible relative to the reputational impact of continued expectation mismatches.

5. Room Quality Is the Weakest Category in the Competitive Set
Category-level sentiment analysis reveals that Rooms is the lowest-performing category at Banff Caribou Lodge & Spa, with only 37.4% of room-related mentions carrying positive sentiment and 37.3% negative. Banff Ptarmigan Inn, a directly comparable property, posts 50.7% positive and 25.9% negative room sentiment under the same methodology, representing a gap of more than 13 percentage points on positive mentions.



The absence of air conditioning is the most frequently cited room complaint and illustrates the value gap acutely. When some guests pay $500 CAD per night, they arrive with expectations commensurate with the price point. One recent guest described paying that rate for a room with "zero AC," a loud fan as a substitute, a non-functioning fridge, and a bathroom with visible cleanliness issues including hair from previous guests on pillowcases, concluding they "definitely wouldn't recommend."

A targeted housekeeping audit and a capital plan for room cooling could address these complaints.

Conclusion
Banff Caribou Lodge & Spa trails its competitive set on every key rating metric, but the analysis suggests actionable responses. By monitoring front desk experience that consistently generates negative sentiment and amenity descriptions that set expectations the property cannot meet are operational and communicational problems, not fundamental quality deficiencies. The property has a loyal base of satisfied guests and genuine strengths in location and amenities; the 1★ tail is being driven by a recoverable subset of avoidable disappointments. Mount Royal Hotel and The Rundlestone Lodge demonstrate that higher ratings and active review engagement go hand in hand, and both are within reach for Banff Caribou Lodge & Spa with targeted intervention.